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Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Friday, January 23, 2026

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- Official floor video (Senate of Virginia, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pmzth3-H23I
- LIS Senate minutes: https://lis.virginia.gov/session-details/20261/minutes-list/S

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[00:00:04] Senate Chamber. This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia. Senate Chamber. Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

[00:05:10] The Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:06:16] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:10:02] Senate chamber.

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[00:11:32] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:12:36] Senate chamber.

[00:14:13] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:16:36] Chamber.

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[00:17:53] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:18:58] Senate Chamber.

[00:20:34] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:22:32] Senate Chamber.

[00:23:04] Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

[00:24:12] The Senate will come to order. The senators will please take their seats. Those persons

[00:29:06] not entitled to the privileges of the floor will retire to the gallery. The senators and all in attendance will please stand if you are able and be led in prayer today by the Reverend Lance Watson, Jr., from St. Paul's Baptist Church in Richmond, and following the prayer, everyone will please remain standing and be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the flag of the United States of America by Senate Page Ann Miller from Richmond. Let us pray. Source of wisdom,

[00:29:43] justice, and compassion, we gather in this chamber at a moment of new beginnings and renewed responsibility. As the new governor and administration step forward to lead we pause to recognize the weight of this transition and the hope it carries for the people we serve. We invite your guiding presence today known by many names and honored through many traditions to shape the work of this day.

[00:30:06] We affirm the shared truth echoed across faiths and moral traditions that leadership rooted in integrity brings flourishing to people. As the Holy Writ teaches, when the righteous thrive, the people rejoice. May this season be marked by wisdom, humility, and a commitment to justice that benefits the whole community. We pray for cooperation across lines of difference, for collaboration that values diverse perspectives, and for the unity that does not erase distinction but honors shared purpose. In the spirit of sacred

[00:30:43] teaching, may the God who gives endurance and encouragement give you the same attitude of mind toward each other. Let mutual respect guide debate and let the common good remain the center of every decision. God, we lift before you the people behind these walls, the families, the workers, the elders, the children, and communities whose lives are shaped by the policies discussed here. Be especially near to those who have historically carried the heaviest burdens and whose voices have too often

[00:31:17] gone unheard. May the impact of this body's work bring equity, safety, opportunity, and dignity to every corner of our state. Bless the governor, the senate, and all public servants with clarity of vision, moral courage, and listening hearts. May this reconvened body labor together in good faith, Mindful that true progress is forged not through division, but through shared responsibility and collective care.

[00:31:46] We offer this moment with gratitude and hope, trusting that wisdom, justice, and compassion will guide our steps and unite our efforts for the good of all. Amen. I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:32:31] The clerk will call the roll. All those present, please vote aye. The clerk will close the roll.

[00:32:51] You have a quorum, Madam President. Senate Journal for Thursday, January 22, 2026. The senator from Arlington moves that the reading of the journal be waived. All in favor of waiving the reading of the journal will record their vote aye.

[00:33:11] Those opposed no, are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 34, noes 4.

[00:33:27] Ayes 34, noes 4. The reading of the journal is waived. The clerk will report any communications from the House of Delegates. We do not have any, Madam President. The clerk will report any communications from the governor.

[00:33:45] We do not have any, Madam President. We have now arrived at the time of our morning hour when we have the honor of welcoming our distinguished guests who are joining us here in the gallery.

[00:34:03] I share my daily reminder about our procedure. A senator will rise and provide an introduction for their visitors, and I will then offer the welcome of the Senate. Please hold your applause until I have completed the Senate's welcome.

[00:34:21] The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Henrico. Thank you so much, Madam Chair. I rise for an announcement. Excuse me, an introduction.

[00:34:37] The senator has the floor. Thank you so much, Madam Chair. Madam Chair, I have to admit that I have come to be so excited about our sessions when I know we have to call in someone because it's the end of the week or there's impeding weather.

[00:34:55] And Dr. Lance Watson, Jr., he is what I like to call as our old reliable. And so if he could please stand. I have come to look forward to hearing his prayers every single time we call, he answers. He is no stranger to this chamber. But for those who do not know him, he is the senior pastor of St. Paul Baptist Church in Richmond. He joins us at the Capitol today.

[00:35:21] Again, we are so honored to have him with us as the respected faith leader and community visionary whose work continues to leave a lasting impact across our commonwealth with many accolades, many achievements uh and a renowned resume madam chair i'd ask that you give him the warm welcome once again of his senate well i thank the senator for that introduction and uh old reliable or maybe young reliable that might be that might be a better better term but thank you so much for

[00:35:54] your consistency in joining us especially as we need uh someone to guide us through the invocation during these days. So we appreciate you offering your words of wisdom and prayer and thank you for being here today. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the Reverend Lance Watson, Jr. The chair recognizes the senator from Roanoke. Good morning, Madam President. Good morning. I rise for

[00:36:32] an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. congratulations my first time speaking since you've become president thank you in your previous role as our chair of education and health you got to know several of the folks we're going to get to hear from today around the capital they're advocating which is the Virginia PTA we've got folks from Fairfax Southwest Virginia Hampton Roads here in Richmond and Henrico and I've got many friends here from Roanoke I think some of them are in the gallery with their colleagues today and they're just here to talk about the importance of our

[00:37:10] strong financial support of public education in the Commonwealth making sure that we provide opportunities of a wide variety so that all students can succeed here in Virginia. I ask that you give them a warm welcome of the Senate. I thank the senator for that introduction and members of our

Virginia PTA if you'll please stand. Thank you so much for joining us here this morning. I know you've been active as you've walked around the Capitol and visited so many of our legislators and their offices. Thank you for your continued advocacy for our

[00:37:46] students and for our schools and for our the health of our education system. Your work is truly appreciated. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the representatives of the Virginia PTA. The chair recognizes the senator from Western Henrico. Thank you Madam President. Madam President I rise for the purposes of introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you Madam President. Madam President if the Dental

[00:38:21] Hygienists Association could please rise. The Virginia Dental Hygienists Association is a professional organization representing over 6,000 licensed dental hygienists across the commonwealth for over 113 years. The profession has worked diligently improving the public's health through promotion of optimal oral health they are essential members of the oral health care workforce delivering preventative and therapeutic services that improve all of our health and so i would hope we would give them a nice senate welcome i thank the senator for that introduction and welcome to the dental

[00:38:56] hygienist association thank you so much not only for the work you do on a daily basis but thank Thank you for visiting the Capitol, visiting your legislators, and sharing the importance and the critical efforts that you are making on behalf of all of your patients.

[00:39:14] Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the representatives of the Dental Hygienist Association.

[00:39:30] The chair recognizes the junior senator from Loudoun County. Good morning, Madam President. Thank you. I rise for a purpose of an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Today in the gallery, we are joined by the student volunteers from Anasudha Community Kitchens.

[00:39:48] Anasudha is a volunteer-driven, licensed kitchen whose mission is to spread love through food in Loudoun County. Through their meal donations to those in need and fundraising efforts through food-based events, in addition to their two flagship programs, the Shelter Feeding Program and the Open Pantry Program, Anasudha brings the community together around the table With their continued donations of more than 6,500 meals a month and their focus on their five pillars, they help combat hunger and food insecurity throughout Northern Virginia, which they could not do without the help of individuals who spread their word and also volunteer.

[00:40:26] They have delivered some tasty samosas to your offices this morning as a token of their gratitude for being here. I hope you will all join me in extending them a warm welcome of the Senate. I thank the senator for that introduction. and welcome to the representatives from the Anasuda Community Kitchen.

[00:40:46] Just hearing about the remarkable work that you are doing in making sure that we are addressing the crisis of hunger of so many in our communities is truly heartwarming. Thank you for your compassion. Thank you for the outreach that you make. And thank you for the samosas that you have delivered to our representatives.

[00:41:04] I thank you for joining us. And senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the Anasuda Community Kitchen Representatives.

[00:41:20] Seeing no further introductions this morning, resolution-- the chair recognizes the senator from Washington. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I rise for a request.

[00:41:36] The senator has the floor. Madam President, I request a leave of absence for my seatmate, the senator from Rockingham, who's away on pressing personal business. The journal will so reflect. Thank you, Senator.

[00:41:53] Seeing no other matters, resolution, petitions, bills are now in order the clerk will call the calendar senate calendar for friday january 23rd 2026 uncontested calendar senate bill on third reading senate bill 96 a bill relating to income tax credit braille labeling program the chair recognizes the senator from western prince william thank you madam president madam president i move passion uh passage of the bill and speaking to the

[00:42:32] bill? The senator has the floor. Thank you so much, Madam President. Madam President, this is the bill to provide tax incentives for Braille shipping labels that are shipping label equipment that companies can purchase. The amended version of this limits those companies to just those that are located in Virginia. I'd also like to thank 39 of our 40 members who have their name on this bill today. One person said that they didn't want to, but for everyone else, y'all are

[00:43:02] cool, have a great weekend, every new passage of the bill. The question is, shall Senate Bill 96 pass? All in favor of the motion will record their votes aye, those opposed no, are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their votes? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 39, no zero. Ayes 39, no zero. Senate Bill 96 passes. Uncontested calendar. Senate bills

[00:43:40] on second reading? The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Good morning, Madam President. Good morning. Madam President, I move that all the Senate bills on second reading on the uncontested calendars on pages two, on page two, Senate bill 89 through 186, the advance to their engrossment and third reading in a block after the adoption of any amendments thereto. Any senators are going to move the bill from the block. Please do so after the clerk has stated the number of them.

[00:44:06] The question is, shall all Senate bills on second reading on the uncontested calendar on page two senate bill 89 through senate bill 186 be engrossed in advance to their third constitutional reading in the block after the adoption of the amendments thereto that any senator desiring to remove a bill from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the bill all in favor of the motion will say aye those opposed no the ayes have it the motion is agreed to, the clerk will read the number of the bills.

[00:44:40] Senate Bill 89, reported from the Committee on Agriculture, Conservation and Natural Resources. Senate Bill 163, reported from the Committee on Agriculture, Conservation and Natural Resources. Senate Bill 186, reported from the Committee on Agriculture, Conservation and Natural Resources.

[00:45:00] The question is, shall the Senate bills be engrossed and advanced to their third reading? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The bills are engrossed and advanced to their third reading.

[00:45:17] Regular calendar, Senate bills on second reading. Senate Bill 6, a bill relating to qualifications of voters' right to vote, persons not entitled to vote. Reported from the Committee on Privileges and Elections.

[00:45:32] The chair recognizes the senator from Hampton. Thank you, Madam President. I move that Senate Bill 6 be engrossed and advanced to its third reading. the senator like to speak to that motion no okay thank you not today the question is shall shall the bill be engrossed in advance to his third reading all in favor of the motion will say aye those opposed no the ayes have it as senate bill six is it grossed in advance to his third reading

[00:46:06] senate bill 58 a bill relating to elections deadline for receipt of absentee ballots and certain other information five o'clock p.m. on the third day after the election reported for the committee on privileges and elections the chair recognizes the senator from Arlington thank you madam president madam president I move that the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading the question is shall Senate bill 58 be engrossed in advance to his third reading all in favor of the motion will say aye any opposed no the eyes have it Senate bill 58 is engrossed

[00:46:45] and advanced Senate bill 169 a bill relating to elections candidates for office challenges to candidate qualifications reported from the committee on privileges and elections the chair recognizes the senator from Western Fairfax thank you madam president I move the bill be engrossed in advance to its third constitutional reading the question is shall Senate bill 169 being grossed in advance to his third constitutional reading all in In favor of the motion, we'll say aye.

[00:47:14] Any opposed, no. Senate Bill 169 is engrossed and advanced. Senate Bill 449, a bill relating to fundamental right to reproductive freedom, reported from the Committee on Privileges and Elections.

[00:47:30] The Chair recognizes the Senator from Northern Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. I move the bill be engrossed and advanced to its third reading. The question is, shall Senate Bill 449 be engrossed and advanced to his third reading? All in favor of the motion will say aye.

[00:47:47] Those opposed, no. Senate Bill 449 is engrossed and advanced. Uncontested calendar, Senate Bill is on first reading. The Chair recognizes the Senator from Eastern Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President.

[00:48:05] Madam President, I move that all the Senate Bill is on the first reading. On the uncontested and regular calendars, pages 4-13, Senate Bills 37-575, that the rules be suspended and the first constitutional reading of the titles be dispensed with. The question is, shall the rules be suspended and the first constitutional reading of the titles of the Senate bills on the uncontested and regular calendars on pages 4-13, Senate Bill 37 through Senate Bill 575 be dispensed with?

[00:48:36] All in favor of the motion will record their votes aye, those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? all the senators voted. Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 39, noes 0. Ayes 39, noes 0. The reading of the titles is dispensed with. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. I move that

[00:49:13] all those bills go by for the day. The question is, shall the bills now go by for the day? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The The ayes have it, the bills do go by for the day.

[00:49:43] Supplemental calendar, number one, for Friday, January 23rd, 2026. Regular calendar, Senate Bill on first reading. Senate Bill 769, relating to General Appropriation Act, Department of Elections.

[00:50:08] The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Inquiry of the clerk, does that complete today's Precinct Omageddon calendar? Yes, sir. Thank you.

[00:50:26] Any other business to come before the Senate? The chair recognizes the senator from Norfolk. If we could just pause, the chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax for an announcement.

[00:50:49] Thank you, Madam President. Ladies and gentlemen, I just wanna make sure everybody knows that today is the final day to be introducing legislation without unanimous consent. And the deadline is at three o'clock. The president pro tem is gonna make a motion here in a second to suspend the rules to allow that.

[00:51:07] Just wanna make sure everybody knows you gotta have it in up here at the desk to Tara et al by 3 p.m. today if you have any bills you're gonna introduce by today or else you're gonna be begging all of us for unanimous consent oh sorry if anybody has one can you raise your hand so they know how many to expect uh six i'd say about 10 12 13 yeah quite a

[00:51:35] few good thank you thank you senator the chair now recognizes again the senator from norfolk thank you madam president madam president i rise to let the begging begin of a unanimous consent bill the senator has the floor thank you madam president i request unanimous consent to introduce a bill related to the city charter of the city of norfolk the question is shall the

[00:52:15] senate grant unanimous consent to introduce a bill relating to the city charter of the city of Norfolk. All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. We hear some clearing of the throat, but no exact no's. Consent of the Senate has been granted to introduce the bill regarding the city charter of the City of Norfolk. The clerk will report any announcements on the desk. Today, Monday Jan... it feels

[00:52:49] like Monday already. Monday, January 26, the Committee for Courts of Justice would meet at 8 a.m. Senate Room A. The Committee on Local Government will meet at 8.30 a.m. in Senate Room B. The Education and Health Subcommittee on Higher Education will meet at 8.30 a.m. Senate Room C. The Democratic Caucus will meet at 11.15 in Senate Room 1. The Republican Caucus will meet at 11.30 a.m. in Senate Room 2. Weekend Weather Report. It's cold. There is a cold weather advisory

[00:53:27] for tonight and early tomorrow for bitter cold and wind chills in the single digits. Today partly sunny, highs in the low 50s. Tonight partly cloudy, turning bitter cold. Lows near 15 with chills between minus 5 degrees and 5 degrees. First alert weather days Saturday, Sunday and Monday for snow and ice. Saturday, mostly cloudy. Snow starts in the evening. Heavy to moderate snow at night

[00:54:00] into the overnight. Highs in the lows at mid-20s. In the evening, snow chance 40% increasing to 100% overnight. Sunday, moderate to heavy snow quickly changes to sleet and ice pellets and or freezing rain around sunrise.

[00:54:23] Several inches of overnight early morning snow before the changeover to a wintry mix. Drive safely and have a warm weekend. The chair recognizes the senator from Portsmouth. Thank you, Madam President.

[00:54:40] Madam President, I rise on the point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor. I was born in 1944 and yesterday was my birthday. I was a child of massive resistance, a time when little girls and boys who looked like me were told plainly and without apology you do not belong. I could not go to the same schools as white children. My neighborhood was underfunded, forgotten and deliberately segregated and every single day the message was the same. The law said I was not equal. I grew up knowing what it feels

[00:55:16] like when the government you live under tells you your voice does not matter and for far too long those same jim crow laws relics of hatred and fear were used to silence people like me especially at the ballot box madam president history was made yesterday a federal court ruled that virginia's lifetime ban on voting for people with felony convictions violates federal law judge john gibney ruled that virginia's constitution went far beyond what congress ever allowed when the commonwealth was readmitted to the union after the civil war the virginia readmission act of 1870 was

[00:55:55] meant to protect the political power of newly freed black americans but virginia did the opposite the court found that the constitution was rewritten again and again on purpose to discriminate to disenfranchise to keep black citizens from the ballot and the lawmakers of that era admitted it they said it to themselves they said it out loud for far more than a century virginia ignored federal laws. For more than a century, voting was treated not as a right, but as a privilege

[00:56:30] granted to or withheld. For more than a century, black Virginians who should have had a voice in shaping their future were locked out of their own democracy. Yesterday, on my birthday, the court said no more. It makes me emotional to think about all the Virginians who should have had the right to vote, but were denied it. But Madam President, the arc of the moral universe is long, but it bends towards justice. No more inventing crimes to silence voters. No more permanent punishments

[00:57:05] after people have paid their debt. No more pretending this system was ever about justice when it was always about keeping control. The ruling makes clear that Virginia only disenfranchised citizens for a very narrow set of crimes. Those which were felonies at common law in 1870. That means the Commonwealth can no longer bar people from voting for almost modern felony convictions and folks who had had the rights ripped away illegally for years will once again be able to vote. Madam President, this is one of the most significant voting right decisions

[00:57:44] in Virginia's in generations. It names the truth that felony disenfranchisement was born from Jim Crow and used to suppress black political power. And after all the history, All of that pain, all of the blood spilled, the lost life, the lost life's loss, and the cruelty rooted in hatred.

[00:58:06] People who were once silenced will finally be able to participate in our democracy and cast a ballot at full American citizens. Madam President, today, the Virginia I and so many have fought for, for our entire lives is one step closer to the promise this nation made at its founding.

[00:58:24] We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal. that they are endowed with certain unalienable rights, life, liberty, and a pursuit of happiness. Thank you so much, Madam President. Thank you, Senator.

[00:58:43] The chair recognizes the senator from Roanoke. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for a brief point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. This July, we will celebrate the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence.

[00:59:03] So many events are happening this year in the lead up to it that are also 250th anniversary events of the events that led to that event. And that was a great event. We're all very proud of Thomas Jefferson's role in being the primary author of the Declaration of Independence.

[00:59:20] This week we had another significant anniversary in the Commonwealth, and that was the 240th anniversary of the Virginia Statute on Religious Freedoms. And that's also associated with Thomas Jefferson. But 240 years ago, Thomas Jefferson wasn't a member of the Virginia House of Burgesses.

[00:59:38] He had introduced it earlier and it had been unsuccessful. We like to think that we always recognize that religious freedom exists in this country and that we should recognize it for everyone. Unfortunately, that's not always the case everyone talks about.

[00:59:54] And so when Jefferson put it up, someone that was as politically effective as Thomas Jefferson had it dashed in the rocks over in what we call the other chamber. And it wasn't until a few years later that a tax bill, that I also get very excited about tax bills, came up that was going to seek to tax every Christian in the Commonwealth, regardless of which church they liked or didn't like, so that that money could go to a specific favorite church.

[01:00:25] And at that time, James Madison and Thomas Jefferson were in communication, said maybe this is a good time for everyone to recognize that religious freedom applies to everyone and so I'm very proud that 240 years ago we did that we recognize it every day here in the Commonwealth and we need to always recognize that religious freedom means for everyone thank you madam president I thank the senator the chair now recognizes the senator from Portsmouth thank you madam president madam president I move that the Senate do now

[01:01:01] adjourn until 12 noon on Monday and that the Senate suspend the rules and direct the clerk to accept legislation to be introduced until 3:00 p.m. today. The question is shall the Senate adjourn until 12 noon Monday and that the Senate suspend the rules and direct the clerk to accept legislation to be introduced until 3:00 p.m. today. All in favor will record their votes aye, those opposed no.

[01:01:28] are the Senators ready to vote? Have all the Senators voted? Does any Senator desire to change their vote? The Clerk will close the roll. Ayes 39, no 0. Ayes 39, no 0. The Senate does now adjourn until 12 noon Monday and the Senate has suspended the rules and directed the Clerk to accept legislation to be introduced until 3 p.m. today.

[01:01:59] This has been a broadcast by the Senate of Virginia from Richmond, Virginia. Visit our YouTube channel for live meetings and session videos, previous recordings, and archival content at youtube.com forward slash at symbol Senate of Virginia.

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